

Oh Chang Young.

Forsaken and found in that familiar forest, how much longer are you going to expect someone, your dear brother or your unkind mother, to save you or these household relations; for one has another and the latter is dead, so just save yourself from this fear of yours. This fear of yours that causes you to scramble for your life is not your real fear but rather a fear from when you were a puny child, so do not mistake this for being the real one. While the grisly creatures hunt you down, do not dwell on this childhood abandonment of yours from over a hundred years ago either; instead, locate yourself Young, and focus entirely on surviving--not the Imoogi, not sung hoon, not the past--absolutely nothing, but surviving. Trust me, just survive this and you won't regret it. Now, at present, let's visit somewhere familiar, shall we?

A childhood Hanok village you stand here, admiring. Before you, stands the aged home, camouflaging with the muddy, manure-reeking ground, wobbling beside a rustic well and complimenting it, is a scratchy straw roof with its walnut-colored wood. The edges of the straw are untrimmed and resemble chops of fine hair and the dirt vases are brimmed to the top with water from blessed rivers. While you're adorned with this cream blazer and ironed white button-down--not a single hair out of place and every aspect about you screaming luxury--you feel nostalgia seeing this home. This home brought so many memories, if only you could remember them clearly. Upon a rotation of a doorknob, you arrive here where you now examine this home. Was it only a moment ago when you were in the comfort of your million-dollar mansion? "Out of all places, it had to be this old house. I must be more wasted than I thought," you shiver. *Bang*. A wooden bat blows the top of your head, and you spin around, while a voice shrieks, "The illegitimate child! It's the illegitimate child born from a fox." Backing away instinctively, you rub the crown of your head. Furrowed brows and widened eyes illustrate your bewilderment and panic. Do you remember these mighty men, clothed with ancient clothing? Remember this body of armed village men with various rods of metal and wooden canes. Remember this villager, brandishing his weapon in your face barking, "Because of him, the animals in this town are all dead." Recall yourself, a buffeted child. "He must've eaten their livers," they fume, and before you knew it, they thrash and beat you, the hammering of the wood against your back ringing in your ears and your powerless arms providing no defense. Not then and not now. Feeling vexed yet incapable, here you are exactly like that buffeted child.

Tears of anger well from the bellows of the villagers cursing: "Kill him! Die, you scoundrel." But more distressing were the apathetic eyes peeking through a tear in the wall, witnessing everything. The clamors of the villagers baying foul insults go mute as your eyes meet and you overwhelmingly want to cry out. Eventually, you swing away the irate villagers, and they dissipate into thin air. You hear your slow pants of air and you scan the area around you while blood drips from the side of your mouth and your heart pounds inside your chest like a buk, but you assure yourself that this is a mere memory. Irregular whimpers of a woman echo through the wooden door ajar, so you venture in with steady footsteps, and the door creaks as you find her crouching down guiltily. She was quivering, and (what a surprise) those same eyes were cast away. Heart aching with a lump in your throat, you confront her, and say, "I knew it." Her frail body is shaking, and she momentarily glances at you before turning away, her hand clenching to a nearby article. Your words cough out despairingly, "You saw everything that day, Eomma(mother)."

She deliberately rose, her forehead wrinkling and lips trembling, "You should've never been born. I tried almost everything to get rid of you while you were still in my womb." Her tone inflates in gradualness and her words spit out with distaste, "I drank the brewed liquid from poisonous plants, rolled down hills.." your eyes waver from her vision, for you desperately want her to stop. "And even banged my stomach against rocks. Being the monster you are, you just wouldn't die. You even survived the beating from all those robust men," she shrieks.

But her voice sank to a whisper, an eerie whisper saying, "You are a monster, my boy." This phrase shreds you into pieces of scrap and deters every affection you felt into a graveyard of idle hopes. You feel this agitation and discomfort clench into a fist, your blood boiling like a steam kettle. You study her crunched-up frown, her repulsive eyes--is this how a mother treats her child? A sinful man you were, but a monster you were not. So how could this woman, whom you call mother, accuse you like this? This woman snatches your hand, screeching, "Let's go. You're coming with me!" But you're older now, Young, and this woman, your dear mother, had no tenderness nor warmth towards you. Leave her. So you ward her arm away, screaming, "Don't touch me!"

But you're taken aback by the cold coat of blood on the back of your head, and as your hand reaches to pat this region, your reality shifts from the nostalgic thing you would call a home to the mass: The forest of the starved. Rising resentment from starved villagers and outcasts from society towards mankind made them into deceased spirits, living yet dead. Flaming red eyes sunken, with charcoal-covered eyelids, and a varnish of vengeance is your memory of them. Your fox ears sensed the sound waves of their gurgling from a mile away, the humming proceeding nearer and nearer for time could freeze as you felt their cold presence. Instantaneously, you briskly swivel around, drawing a spare ax from your pocket to ax the sickening corpses, slashing their bodies left and right. But these are feeble attempts. The turquoise stone-skinned spirits, vibrant with gory lesions from their past life, stagger greedily, and their ripped, tattered jeogori and muted hanboks are the clothing that they wear; moreover, being plagued with the sins of the previous dynasty. Wearing traditional Jipsins crafted from straw, these feet stagger rapidly upward the tree, whereas the arid and cold hands pin you upside down. "Ahh-uh" - Your back scrapes against the rugged bark, and your head pounds as it thrashes on this tree. Colossal agony is what you feel despite the layers of your sweat-drenched white button-down. You whine helplessly as your head thumps the solid tree, your ears ringing with the furious snarls of the dead spirits, driving you mad. You feel the frigid, sandpaper hands, tear your clothes and the decayed nails claw into your flesh. Your red, organic flesh. You feel the tips of your bleak hair flap as you jerk your bloody and wounded face away from the razor claws of the dead spirits, swiftly dodging them by a few centimeters. You clench the handle of the ax, its polished wood firm in your grasp. They haul you fiercely up and down, dizzying your brain, you flail your arms wildly as more spirits try to devour your flesh. Your eyes tirelessly gaze at the sea of new spirits gathering to feast. A swarming shoal of piranhas, gnawing gruesomely at the fresh bite and defiling the flesh with ink from their tainted teeth. Being gruesomely eaten by these man-eating creatures, your mind clings to the small hope of salvage.

"I knew it, that jerk only cares about his lady," you mutter. Now your head spins with a thousand thoughts, and it is now when you rue your decision of joining the Imoogi. Now you are aware, aren't you? Have you now come around to the fact that you're a pawn in his game, a

way the cold-blooded serpent could reach his nemesis, the powerful mountain fox, you call your brother?

You rest your heavy eyes swallowing this ill fate of yours, when you hear the thunderous yell of a familiar voice, "Hey, kid!" You see a sliver of red as a shadowy figure emerges. You gape as you take in his tall, slick figure clothed all-black, shoulders rolled back, the obsidian drape of his coat receding behind him as he spins, slashing the cursed bodies of the spirits. He grunts as he smoothly unsheathes his sword, embroidered with gold letters of Hangul, *shinggg*. Look at you, your mouth hangs open and your body freezes! Try to hold back this heightened joy you feel, but you can't.

"Sunghoon?" you question, and the disbelief still holds onto you. He hacks the dead spirits ruthlessly, with the cold trickles of their blood splattering across his face like paint. Under his narrow eyes, his copper hair sweeps, he strains the veins of his neck and he plunders his sword swiftly at every opponent. You realize this is only a fragment of his power, his gumihwo power. You hear the silver blade nimbly piercing through the dead spirit that's clutching you, the grip of his hefty arms loosening up as his body tumbles down, drifting down on the rest of the spirits whilst pulling you towards the earth. Petrified, you coil and inch away from the squirming limbs beside you of the dead-but-alive corpses. Meanwhile, he yanks the golden end of his sword bolted to the ground. He's beaming as he speedily approaches you, his head high, "I heard you cursing me out," he proclaims facetiously.

He lends his bare hand to you, and you examine it doubtfully, your eyebrows weigh down and your nose crinkle, you mutter, "I don't need your help!" waving his hand off. You see his expression drop. Indeed, he is here for another reason besides fraternal concern. He always favored his woman, so why did he choose you? Gurgling to life once again, the spirits bellow and groan as they surround you and Sunghoon and therefore compel two adverse poles to bond together, like the two ends of a magnet. "Now is not the time to be so arrogant," Sunghoon advised. You whirl your head to look at him. Arrogance? Surely, he was to talk. *RAUUGGH*. You observe the lamented scrambling slowly towards you, snarling its pointed fangs and clamoring as they eyed you hungrily and your eyes circle side to side, observing that the movements of the dead are now slow.

"You're not him," you proclaim. Perhaps this was a hallucination, a ploy, a scheme.

"Sunghoon wouldn't come to save me," you declare, studying his reaction.

The edge of his face forms a smile, "You're not wrong, I guess," he replies. Not wrong? Bewilderment muddles your brain.

"Show me proof that you're Sunghoon" you interrogate, edging the axe towards the dead. The perished, moped closer and closer.

"Proof? Like my social security number?" he teases. You are in the midst of survival, yet here he is being cheeky. Admittedly, that was very Sunghoon. His mind searches, his mouth fissures and his smile widens. Recalling and gazing at you, he illustrates that day,

"Jwibulnori(popular Korean game), on the night of the first full moon. After having fun with flames," you concentrate, stunned by the details.

He continues, "After having fun with flames, you wet the bed." Eyes widening with embarrassment, you gawk at Sunghoon. "I called you this for three years."

"Shut it," you blurt out, but of course, he does not.

Feeling the heat rising to your cheeks, you flush with humiliation.

Nevertheless, he yells it out: "Bed-wetter!"

One of the dead spirits pounces between you and Sunghoon, and you both swivel hastily, your hair sailing in the air. Fighting side to side with Sunghoon, your memory flashes to when you were only a child.

A resolute Sunghoon in his mountain fox form with his red hair present but with a ribbon tied and extensions of platinum blonde descending to his shoulders and he wore an elegant black hanbok with white and red trims adorned with gold ornaments and his large sleeves the color of the rose of Sharon and his sword still the same. Compared to his towering body, you were tiny; your dark hair was long and loosely tied up. His long sword was extended on his right shoulder while you struck him at numerous points with your ax, but he veered and deflected it.

Now, you wrench the ax from the tree, glowering, you vehemently ax the spirits, steering aside from their vicious claws. You attempt to count the mob of dead drawing near. Five to your right, (scrambling behind the tree) seven to your left (striking Sunghoon) two in your front (currently bombarding you)... but wait there's more? You jab your ax into the sickly-blue spirit, it's foul blood sputtering like a geyser. You shove and thrust a spirit onto the tree with your ax, feeling satisfied by little reprisal. Adrenaline rushes through your veins and numbs the acute pains of your limbs. Just then, a fearsome spirit lunges at you and you merely swerve, plummeting to the ground. You reluctantly set the warm ax in your other hand, and clasp your hand firmly into Sunghoon's, as he strenuously pulls you up. "I'm going to kill you" you croak, "them first" he signals with a transparent grin. Twirling and bending down, you slit a spirit across its chest, causing it to tumble over. Maybe the spirits weren't all strong, were they. The expired had multiplied once again like swarms of drosophila, and you knew their craving for your ripe flesh. Now that you have swallowed a portion of your pride, you realize that to semi-defeat these everliving spirits, you and Sunghoon would need to act as one. So you act like a tramp and you feel the pressure of Sunghoon's feet climb your back, as he soars in the air, his stealthy sword slicing the everlasting spirits. Sunghoon and you tirelessly shove and *shing* hordes of the dead, but their vigor is untouchable. The numbers grew and grew and grew. You feel the sand from the hourglass sift. Because of the masses appearing from the dense trees, Sunghoon tugs your shoulder from the fabric of your blazer and trails you forward, swaying you in his sight and screaming, "Run!"